Russian narrative of the war against Ukraine.

Of course, Stalin, always well aware of this leftist sympathy in the West, seized the opportunities offered to him, not least because Nazi Germany became a very serious, real and direct threat to Russia. With the advent of Communism, Russia's consistent strategic interest in Eastern Europe, which went back to the time of Peter the Great, was revived with the missionary zeal of the Communist revolution. To be fair to the Soviets, it should be said that Stalin was also afraid that right-wing or otherwise hostile governments in some Eastern European countries could facilitate German attack on Russia, which eventually, as we saw, was what happened. Hungary, Romania and Bulgaria hoped that siding with Germany might give them back territories lost in the aftermath of World War I. But Poland, the Baltic States and Finland were, above all, frightened by the prospects of Russian invasion. These countries did not want to be protected from the Germans by a Soviet occupation.

Unfortunately, the Soviet Union did not hesitate to address its own security concerns, even to the extent of signing a treaty with Nazi Germany at the expense of the smaller countries sandwiched between the two great powers. In addition, one must not forget the eagerness that still existed for the export of revolution: when the war between Germany and the Soviet Union eventually broke out, Moscow hoped that the fight against Nazism, and also the common Slavic roots, would make it much easier to install Communist or at least leftist governments in Eastern Europe. This is exactly what happened in 1945. Cynically, one might say that Eastern Europe got rid of the Nazis in four to six years, but it fell under Soviet control for 50 years. Eastern European fears of what the Soviet Union might do actually became true; the pre-war fears of Communism turned into reality too – in the Eastern part of the continent. But how did it actually happen?

As we saw before, with Hitler on the rise, the Soviet Union was initially doing all it could to avoid conflict with Germany and asked Communist parties across Europe to sit by idly. It was not until the German attack on the Soviet Union in April 1941 that Communist parties around Europe were ordered to begin armed resistance. A part of Communist tactics to build up resistance movements was the idea of the so-called National Fronts – loose coalitions of all political parties that were willing to engage in resistance against the Nazis. The concept had its origin in France in the mid-1930s as